4. HTML — HTML Tables

Index: HTML tutorial
Previous: Links, Images and Lists
Next: HTML Forms

The table in this module is a payslip for Ananya Rao. Amounts are in ₹. September 2026. The CSS module styles this table. The markup here is the data.

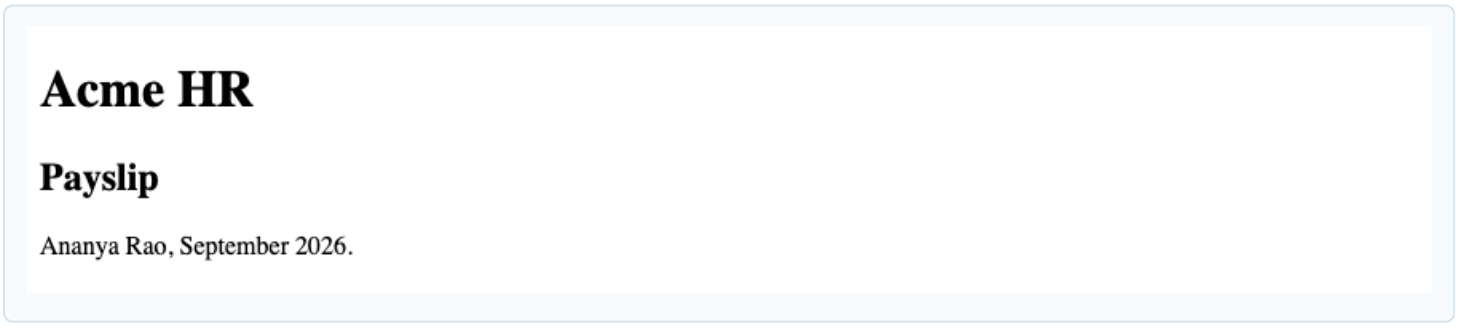
1. Introduction to HTML Tables

A table is data in rows and columns. A payslip is that kind of data: a label and an amount on each row. The directory page is not a table. Cards and headings lay out a page. A table lays out a grid of facts.

Example

```
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html lang="en">
<head>
  <meta charset="UTF-8">
  <meta name="viewport" content="width=device-width, initial-scale=1.0">
  <title>Acme HR — Payslip</title>
</head>
<body>
  <header>
    <h1>Acme HR</h1>
  </header>
  <main>
    <h2>Payslip</h2>
    <p>Ananya Rao, September 2026.</p>
  </main>
</body>
</html>
```

This will produce the following result:



2. `<table>`

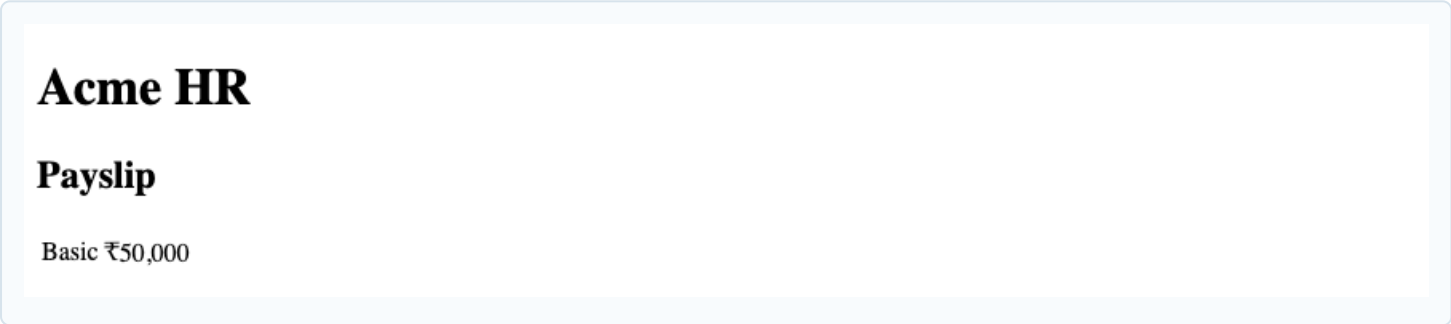
`<table>` wraps the rows. The browser lines the cells up. Put the payslip in `<main>`, after a heading. The heading is not inside the table. The table's own name is the caption, in the next section.

Example

```
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html lang="en">
<head>
```

```
  <meta charset="UTF-8">
  <meta name="viewport" content="width=device-width, initial-scale=1.0">
  <title>Acme HR — Table</title>
</head>
<body>
  <header>
    <h1>Acme HR</h1>
  </header>
  <main>
    <h2>Payslip</h2>
    <table>
      <tr>
        <td>Basic</td>
        <td>₹50,000</td>
      </tr>
    </table>
  </main>
</body>
</html>
```

This will produce the following result:



3. `<caption>`

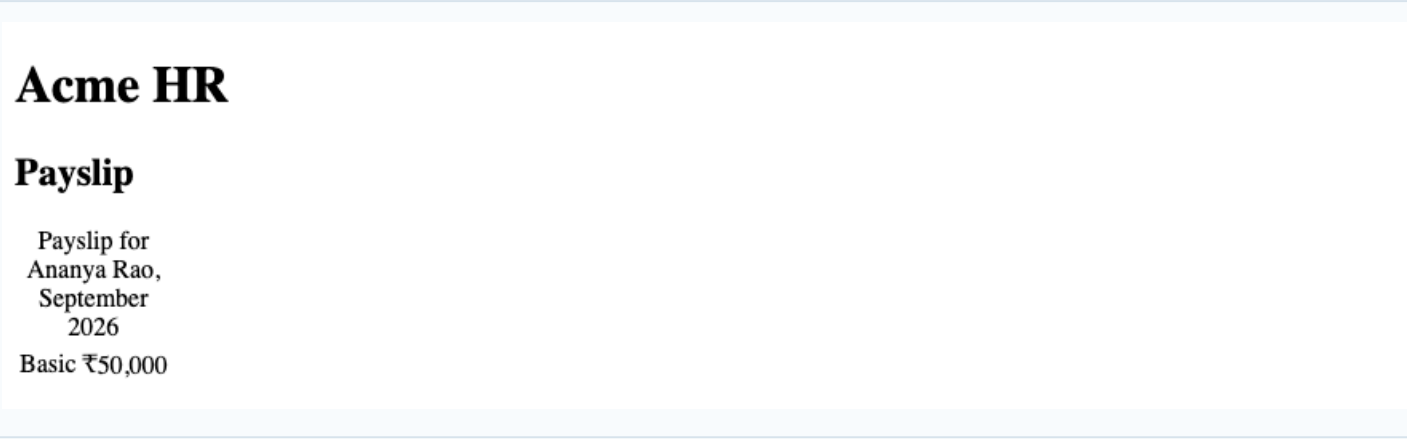
`<caption>` is the name of the table. It is the first element inside `<table>`. Screen readers announce it before the rows. The payslip caption names the employee and the month. The page still has one `<h1>`, Acme HR, and an `<h2>` for the section.

Example

```
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html lang="en">
<head>
  <meta charset="UTF-8">
  <meta name="viewport" content="width=device-width, initial-scale=1.0">
  <title>Acme HR — Caption</title>
</head>
<body>
  <header>
    <h1>Acme HR</h1>
  </header>
  <main>
    <h2>Payslip</h2>
    <table>
      <caption>Payslip for Ananya Rao, September 2026</caption>
      <tr>
        <td>Basic</td>
        <td>₹50,000</td>
      </tr>
    </table>
```

```
  </main>
</body>
</html>
```

This will produce the following result:



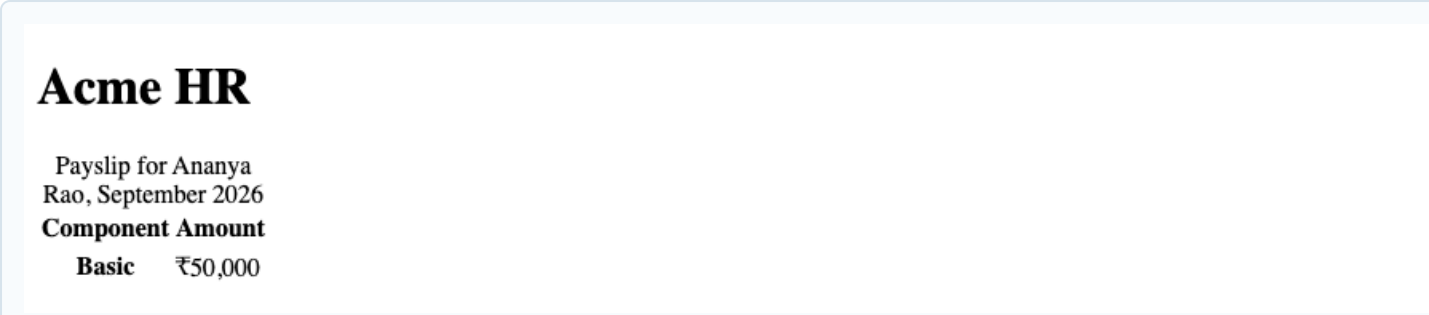
4. `<tr>`, `<th>`, `<td>`

`<tr>` is a row. `<th>` is a header cell. `<td>` is a data cell. Header cells name the column or the row. Data cells hold the amounts. Use `<th>` for "Basic" when that cell labels the amount beside it.

Example

```
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html lang="en">
<head>
  <meta charset="UTF-8">
  <meta name="viewport" content="width=device-width, initial-scale=1.0">
  <title>Acme HR — Cells</title>
</head>
<body>
  <header>
    <h1>Acme HR</h1>
  </header>
  <main>
    <table>
      <caption>Payslip for Ananya Rao, September 2026</caption>
      <tr>
        <th>Component</th>
        <th>Amount</th>
      </tr>
      <tr>
        <th>Basic</th>
        <td>₹50,000</td>
      </tr>
    </table>
  </main>
</body>
</html>
```

This will produce the following result:



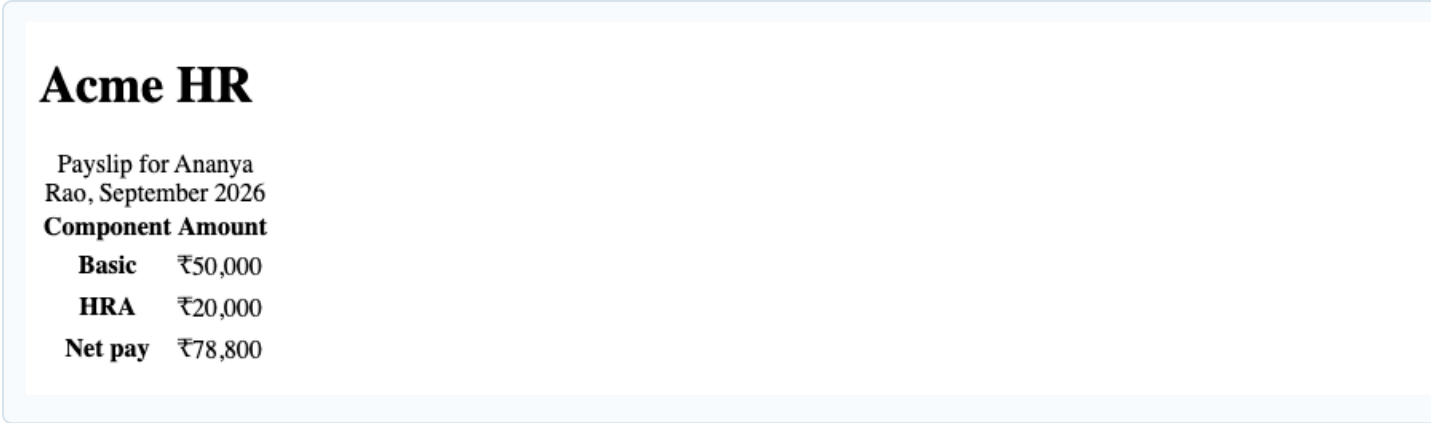
5. `<thead>`, `<tbody>`, `<tfoot>`

`<thead>` holds the column headings. `<tbody>` holds the line items. `<tfoot>` holds the summary, such as net pay. The browser may repeat the head when a long table prints. Keep net pay in the footer so it stays the total, not one more earning.

Example

```
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html lang="en">
<head>
  <meta charset="UTF-8">
  <meta name="viewport" content="width=device-width, initial-scale=1.0">
  <title>Acme HR — Table sections</title>
</head>
<body>
  <header>
    <h1>Acme HR</h1>
  </header>
  <main>
    <table>
      <caption>Payslip for Ananya Rao, September 2026</caption>
      <thead>
        <tr>
          <th>Component</th>
          <th>Amount</th>
        </tr>
      </thead>
      <tbody>
        <tr>
          <th>Basic</th>
          <td>₹50,000</td>
        </tr>
        <tr>
          <th>HRA</th>
          <td>₹20,000</td>
        </tr>
      </tbody>
      <tfoot>
        <tr>
          <th>Net pay</th>
          <td>₹78,800</td>
        </tr>
      </tfoot>
    </table>
  </main>
</body>
</html>
```

This will produce the following result:



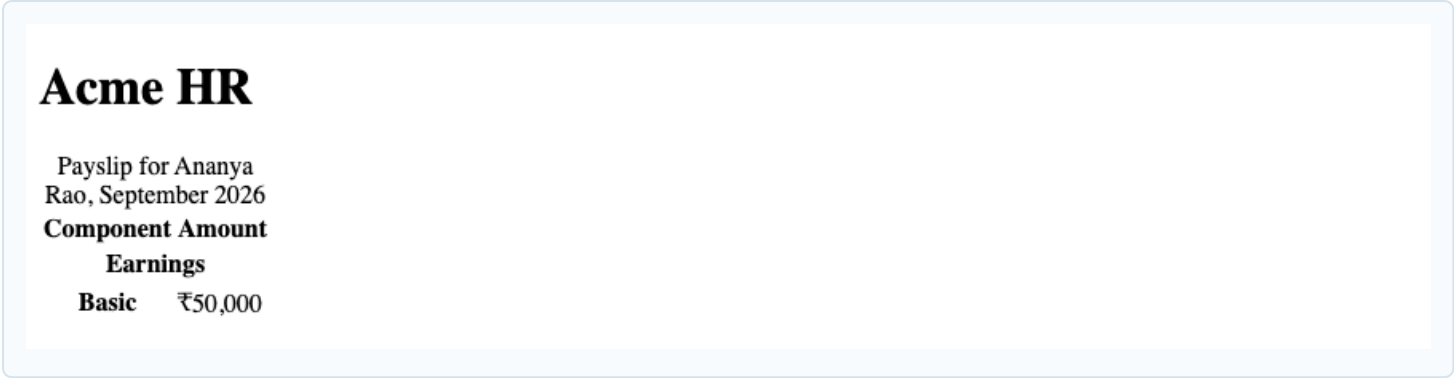
6. `colspan` and `rowspan`

`colspan` stretches a cell across columns. `rowspan` stretches it across rows. A row that only says "Earnings" spans both columns. The cells it covers are omitted from that row. Count the columns so each row still adds up to the same width.

Example

```
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html lang="en">
<head>
  <meta charset="UTF-8">
  <meta name="viewport" content="width=device-width, initial-scale=1.0">
  <title>Acme HR — Span</title>
</head>
<body>
  <header>
    <h1>Acme HR</h1>
  </header>
  <main>
    <table>
      <caption>Payslip for Ananya Rao, September 2026</caption>
      <thead>
        <tr>
          <th>Component</th>
          <th>Amount</th>
        </tr>
      </thead>
      <tbody>
        <tr>
          <th colspan="2">Earnings</th>
        </tr>
        <tr>
          <th>Basic</th>
          <td>₹50,000</td>
        </tr>
      </tbody>
    </table>
  </main>
</body>
</html>
```

This will produce the following result:



7. `scope` and Accessible Tables

`scope` tells which cells a header labels. `scope="col"` means the column under that header. `scope="row"` means the row beside that header. The amount column uses `scope="col"`. "Basic" uses `scope="row"`. A caption names the table. Together, a screen reader can say "Basic, ₹50,000" instead of a bare number.

Attribute	Payslip use
`scope="col"`	Component, Amount
`scope="row"`	Basic, HRA, Net pay
`<caption>`	Who the payslip is for, and which month

Example

```
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html lang="en">
<head>
  <meta charset="UTF-8">
  <meta name="viewport" content="width=device-width, initial-scale=1.0">
  <title>Acme HR — Scope</title>
</head>
<body>
  <header>
    <h1>Acme HR</h1>
  </header>
  <main>
    <table>
      <caption>Payslip for Ananya Rao, September 2026</caption>
      <thead>
        <tr>
          <th scope="col">Component</th>
          <th scope="col">Amount</th>
        </tr>
      </thead>
      <tbody>
        <tr>
          <th scope="row">Basic</th>
          <td>₹50,000</td>
        </tr>
      </tbody>
    </table>
  </main>
</body>
</html>
```

This will produce the following result:



8. Real-World Data Tables

This is the September payslip. Basic ₹50,000, HRA ₹20,000, and special allowance ₹15,000 make a gross of ₹85,000. PF ₹6,000 and professional tax ₹200 leave a net pay of ₹78,800. Earnings and deductions are grouped with a spanning header row.

Example

```
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html lang="en">
<head>
  <meta charset="UTF-8">
  <meta name="viewport" content="width=device-width, initial-scale=1.0">
  <title>Acme HR — September payslip</title>
</head>
<body>
  <header>
    <h1>Acme HR</h1>
    <nav>
      <a href="directory.html">Directory</a>
      <a href="leave.html">Leave</a>
    </nav>
  </header>
  <main>
    <h2>Payslip</h2>
    <table>
      <caption>Payslip for Ananya Rao, September 2026</caption>
      <thead>
        <tr>
          <th scope="col">Component</th>
          <th scope="col">Amount</th>
        </tr>
      </thead>
      <tbody>
        <tr>
          <th colspan="2" scope="colgroup">Earnings</th>
        </tr>
        <tr>
          <th scope="row">Basic</th>
          <td>₹50,000</td>
        </tr>
        <tr>
          <th scope="row">HRA</th>
          <td>₹20,000</td>
        </tr>
        <tr>
          <th scope="row">Special allowance</th>
          <td>₹15,000</td>
```

```
        </tr>
        <tr>
          <th scope="row">Gross</th>
          <td>₹85,000</td>
        </tr>
        <tr>
          <th colspan="2" scope="colgroup">Deductions</th>
        </tr>
        <tr>
          <th scope="row">PF</th>
          <td>₹6,000</td>
        </tr>
        <tr>
          <th scope="row">Professional tax</th>
          <td>₹200</td>
        </tr>
      </tbody>
      <tfoot>
        <tr>
          <th scope="row">Net pay</th>
          <td>₹78,800</td>
        </tr>
      </tfoot>
    </table>
  </main>
</body>
</html>
```

This will produce the following result:



Acme HR

Directory Leave

Payslip

Payslip for Ananya Rao, September 2026

Component	Amount
Earnings	
Basic	₹50,000
HRA	₹20,000
Special allowance	₹15,000
Gross	₹85,000
Deductions	
PF	₹6,000
Professional tax	₹200
Net pay	₹78,800

9. Tables vs Page Layout

Use a table for the payslip. Do not use a table to place the header, the directory, and the leave form. Those regions are header, main, and sections. CSS Flexbox and Grid place them. A table read aloud becomes a grid of cells. A layout table would announce the whole page that way.

Example

```
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html lang="en">
<head>
  <meta charset="UTF-8">
  <meta name="viewport" content="width=device-width, initial-scale=1.0">
  <title>Acme HR — Data table</title>
</head>
<body>
  <header>
    <h1>Acme HR</h1>
  </header>
  <main>
    <h2>Payslip</h2>
    <p>The header and this paragraph are not table cells.</p>
    <table>
      <caption>Payslip for Ananya Rao, September 2026</caption>
      <tr>
        <th scope="row">Net pay</th>
        <td>₹78,800</td>
      </tr>
    </table>
  </main>
</body>
</html>
```

This will produce the following result:

